

'CHESS IN INDIA IS NOW ATTRACTING MORE CORPORATE SUPPORT AND GOVERNMENT INTEREST'

India's rising chess star, R. Praggnanandhaa, reflects on the country's golden moment at the Chess Olympiad, the **chess boom sweeping the nation** and the mental challenges that come with the game.

Mayank
mayank.c@thehindu.co.in

R. Praggnanandhaa, one of India's brightest chess talents, has firmly established himself among the global elite. In 2023, he made history by becoming only the second Indian, after Viswanathan Anand, to reach the World Cup final. His remarkable journey continued as he qualified for the prestigious Candidates tournament, alongside compatriots D. Gukesh and Vidit Gujrathi. Although Praggnanandhaa finished fifth, Gukesh went on to make history as the youngest-ever World Championship challenger following his victory in Canada.

2024 has been a landmark year for Indian chess. The country secured its first-ever gold in both the Open and Women's sections at the Chess Olympiad in Hungary. Praggnanandhaa played a key role, representing India on the second board, and delivered a solid score of 6/10.



In an exclusive interview with *Sportstar*, Praggnanandhaa discussed his advocacy for standardised time control in classical chess to enhance consistency in the game.

He also reflected on India's golden moment at the Chess Olympiad, the ongoing boom in the sport across the country, and the mental challenges players face.

How important is this Olympiad gold for India, especially with the growing popularity of chess in the country?

This gold is incredibly significant for Indian chess. It will inspire many more children to take up the game, and it will encourage broader involvement across the country. We're finally getting recognised for our achievements.

It's also attracting more corporate support and interest from government, which is good for the